

Gambling Industry Donations to Political Parties and MPs: A Public Health Loophole That Must Be Closed

Open letter to the Prime Minister; leaders of the Labour, Conservative, Liberal Democrat, Green, SNP and Plaid Cymru parties; the Minister for the Cabinet Office; Minister responsible for elections policy; Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport; Minister responsible for gambling; officers of the APPG on Gambling Reform; and members of Peers for Gambling Reform. *Rt Hon Andy Burnham MP; Rt Hon Kemi Badenoch MP; Sir Ed Davey MP; Zack Polanski; John Swinney MSP; Rhun ap Iorwerth MS; Rt Hon Louise Haigh MP; Florence Eshalomi MP; Rt Hon Lisa Nandy MP; Vicky Foxcroft MP; Baroness Twycross; Sir Iain Duncan Smith MP; Alex Ballinger MP; Dr Becky Cooper MP; Lord Foster of Bath; and members of Peers for Gambling Reform.*

Parliament is currently strengthening safeguards around political finance, with attention being given to foreign money, shell companies, transparency requirements, and other routes through which vested interests may exert influence on public policy.¹ Yet one significant source of potential influence remains largely absent from these discussions: the gambling industry. These questions have acquired renewed urgency amid intense recent scrutiny of large private donations and renewed debate over whether stronger controls on political funding are required.

This omission is striking. Gambling-related harms are now widely recognised as a major public health issue, associated with financial hardship, mental ill-health, relationship breakdown, homelessness, and increased risk of suicide.² These harms affect not only the individual who gambles, but also families, children, communities, and wider society.

Recent gambling reforms have acknowledged the importance of protecting public policy from industry influence. The introduction of a statutory levy to fund research, prevention and treatment represents a welcome shift away from the previous voluntary system, under which gambling operators could influence both the scale and destination of funding. **The principle underlying these reforms is clear: organisations with a direct commercial interest in gambling policy should not directly fund the research, prevention and treatment systems concerned with gambling-related harm.** As researchers and practitioners working in the gambling harms field – including recipients of funding from the new statutory levy – we have welcomed these reforms as an important step towards greater independence, transparency, and public confidence.

It is from this perspective that we are concerned by the **continued absence of equivalent safeguards within the political system itself.** Commercial gambling interests remain free to donate to political parties and provide hospitality to elected representatives, including those responsible for shaping gambling legislation and regulation. Between 2018 and 2023, gambling industry spending on parliamentary hospitality increased tenfold.³ Reporting based on Electoral Commission records found that gambling industry figures had made just under £400,000 in political donations since March 2020.⁴ Newer analysis extends this picture considerably. Across 2020–2026, the study identified 127 political donations worth £7.73 million from donors with confirmed active commercial connections to gambling, alongside extensive parliamentary hospitality and ministerial engagement.⁵ Importantly, this does not

imply that individual donations were motivated by gambling interests – rather, it demonstrates the scale of commercial gambling connections within the political system.

The Government has accepted that conflicts of interest matter in research, prevention, and treatment. It is increasingly difficult to explain why the same principle should not apply to political funding. Accordingly, we call on all the political parties addressed above to voluntarily prohibit donations, gifts, hospitality, and other financial support from commercial gambling interests. Such action could be implemented immediately, without legislation, and would demonstrate a clear commitment to transparency, policy integrity, and the protection of public health.

Dr James Close, University of Plymouth; Dr Kishan Patel, Gambling Harm UK; Ben Jones, Gambling Harm UK; Frankie Graham, CEO, Betknowmore UK; Liz Riley, Betknowmore UK; Professor Sharon Collard, University of Bristol; Dr Philip Newall, University of Bristol; Dr Raffaello Rossi, University of Bristol; Professor Joanne Lloyd, University of Wolverhampton; Dr Ryan Statton, University of Plymouth; Dr Jamie Wheaton, University of Bristol; Dr Stuart G. Spicer, University of Plymouth; Ms Sara Davies, University of Bristol; Professor Carolyn Downs, University of Greater Manchester; Dr Thomas Mills, PHIRST South Bank; Dr Elvira Bolat, Bournemouth University Business School; Scott Cairney, University of York; Professor Matt Field, School of Psychology, University of Sheffield; Caroline Jawad, University of Wales Trinity Saint David; Aaron Abbott, Founder & Managing Director, Against The Odds Education & Awareness CIC; Mark Conway, Gambling Lived Experience Network (GLEN); David Quinti, Gambling Lived Experience Network (GLEN); Helen Donohoe, Gambling Lived Experience Network (GLEN); Hazel Squires, University of Sheffield; Professor Nigel Sherriff, University of Brighton; Dr Alexandra Sawyer, University of Brighton; Dr Glen Dighton, Bournemouth University; Oliver Townsend. Michael Khara, Alekhya Datla & Joshua Dawes from the LSBU Youth Engagement Panel for Gambling Harms.

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